

Engelsk C

Collected Texts

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Chapter I

Voice

Have You Heard of Oscar Wilde?

Stephen Fry

2012

I grew up in the country, deep in the country. The nearest major library was a twelve-mile bicycle ride into the city of Norwich. I was lucky to live in a house filled with books and to have parents who loved to read, but by the time I approached teenage my appetite for reading, combined with my more or less chronic insomnia, meant that I needed more, far
5 more books to consume daily. Every other Thursday, a mobile library (in the form of a large grey pantechicon that would today look absurdly old-fashioned) would come along and park not five minutes' walk from our house. This was my lifeline to the outside world. A quaint battleship-grey modem that linked me to the huge past and present that seemed so impossibly far from the lanes of rural Norfolk.

10 Aged eleven, one Saturday afternoon I sat in front of our little black and white television set (despite the glowering disapproval of my father who thought – quite rightly of course – that television was a vulgar and despicable thing and that no healthy child should watch it, especially during the hours of sunlight) and watched breathless with enthralled disbelief as they screened a film directed by Anthony 'Puffin' Asquith. It was called The Importance of
15 Being Earnest and it left me simply boggling with excitement. I had never heard language used in such a way, had never known that the rhythms of a sentence could be so beautiful, that meanings could turn with such wit on the hinge of a 'but' or an 'unless' – in short I had never known that writing could do more than tell a story, that it could excite in the way that music does. I remembered whole lines of dialogue and repeated them: phrases like 'I hope,
20 Cecily, I shall not offend you if I state quite frankly and openly that you seem to me to be in every way the visible personification of absolute perfection' and 'some aunts are tall, some aunts are not tall. That is a matter that surely an aunt may be allowed to decide for herself'. I hugged these to me as I watched the credits roll by and memorised a name.

The following Thursday I ran to the corner of the lane and threw myself inside the mobile
25 library the moment the door at the rear had opened and the steps been let down. 'Have you heard of Oscar Wilde?' I squealed to the cardiganed librarian within who clutched her beads in alarm at the urgency and intensity of my attack. 'Goodness me, young man ...' 'Do you have a play he wrote called The Importance of Being Earnest?' 'Well now ...' 'Please, I have to read it!' After what seemed an age we found a copy which was duly stamped. I ran home
30 and up the stairs and into my bedroom.

I read The Importance of Being Earnest three or four times a day every day for two weeks. Then I returned it. I knew the whole play off by heart and can still distress companions with long quotations from it. 'What else do you have by Oscar Wilde?' I wanted to know. It was a different librarian and she found me a copy of the Complete Works.

35 Two weeks later I was back to have it restamped. I had read it from cover to cover, but I wanted to read it all again and again.

Another Library Thursday came and I reluctantly returned the Complete Works and asked if there was anything else by Oscar Wilde I could read. 'The Complete Works means the com-

plete works,' the librarian explained. 'Oh but there must be something else ...' The librarian
40 gave a sigh and then looked me up and down. 'I'm not sure ... but there is ...' 'Yes? Yes?' She
walked along the central corridor of the van and stooped low in the biography section ... her
face was flushed as she straightened and placed a book uncertainly into my hands. 'I really
don't know if ... how old are you, young man?' 'Thirteen,' I lied. It was an age that seemed
impossibly mature. 'Well ...' The book was called *The Trials of Oscar Wilde* and was written
45 by someone called H. Montgomery Hyde.

I took it home and read it. It was a book that changed my life. The heroic lord of language
who had captivated me so entirely turned out to have had a secret life. And the more I read
the faster my heart beat. For I knew that I shared the same secret. I had never quite dared tell
myself this truth but reading of Wilde's arrest and trial I could not but know it to be true.

50 It was shattering, terrible, liberating, stimulating, appalling, wonderful and incredible all at
once.

The mobile library a fortnight later had nothing more to offer so the following morning I
caught a little motor coach early in the morning and went to Norwich. There in Esperanto
Way stood the city's great library, since burned in a fire and replaced by a fine one complete
55 with cafés and all kinds of modern excitements.

It was here that I discovered how one book could lead one to another. Bibliographies and
footnotes suggested new names, new books, new writers, whole new areas to be discovered.
It was an analogue card-indexed way of mouse-clicking from one link to another. A little
more laborious perhaps, but breathlessly exciting.

60 Over the next few years the trial and trail of Oscar had led me to read Gide and Genet, Auden
and Orton, Norman Douglas and Ronald Firbank. Unforgettable, transformative books for
me were that same H. Montgomery Hyde's *The Other Love*, Roger Peyrefitte's *The Exile of
Capri and Special Friendships*, Angus Stewart's *Sandel* and Michael Campbell's *Lord Dis-
miss Us*. I read of man-love, boy-love and free love. I clutched to myself the dark secrets of
65 the infamous Book 13 of the Greek Anthology and the Venice letters in *Quest for Corvo*. I
read Cuthbert Worsley's *Flannelled Fool* and Robin Maugham's *Escape from the Shadows*.
From over the Atlantic I encountered Gore Vidal and John Rechy. I discovered the Tangier
set, by way of Michael Davies, Paul Bowles, William Burroughs and dozens of others.

70 For a gay youth growing up in the early '70s a library was a way of showing that I was not
alone. There was an element of titillation and breath-taking possibility, even the chance of a
fumbled encounter, but there was vindication too. Some of the best, finest, truest, cleverest
minds that ever held a pen in their hands had been like me.

It was almost a side-effect that this caused me to educate myself to a degree which was be-
yond anything a school could hope to achieve. My own appetite for knowledge and reading
75 and connection had led me, and that is how education works, not by spoon-feeding, but
by stimulating the appetite so that children cannot wait to feed themselves. Between the
ages of twelve and fourteen I read hundreds and hundreds of books, but more importantly I
became unafraid of reading. Great Writers, I discovered, were not to be bowed down before
and worshipped, but embraced and befriended. Their names resounded through history not
80 because they had massive brows and thought deep incomprehensible thoughts, but because
they opened windows in the mind, they put their arms round you and showed you things
you always knew but never dared to believe. Even if their names were terrifyingly foreign
and intellectual-sounding, Dostoevsky, Baudelaire or Cavafy, they turned out to be charm-
ing and wonderful and quite unalarming after all. Late Henry James was a struggle, I will

85 confess, and some of the longer sentences in Proust would lose me entirely, but all in all, by
the time I was fourteen I knew that being gay was a kind of dark blessing, an awful privilege
and I knew that, as Oscar once wrote on a photograph to an admirer, 'The secret of life is in
art.'

Without libraries none of this would have been possible. They are still to me places of in-
90 credible glamour, possibility, power, excitement and pleasure. Of course the world wide
web and the wonders of the digital age, as well as advances in social understanding, decency
and common sense make it less likely that a gay teenager need ever grow up feeling alone,
but the downside to that huge advance is that that same teenager may never be led to those
95 magical municipal labyrinths whose shelves contain so much and the existence of which for
the better part of two hundred years has so immeasurably improved the quality for so many
millions of ordinary lives.

How th'Irth Wint Rong by Hapless Joey@homeskool.guv

Gregory Maguire

2013

OK OK.

I am riting on this paper the old-timey way with a pen. This is my 5st copy and the last copy. Its no good I dont care. Kick me outa homeskool, what happens, Im alreddy home. Ha ha.

- The Big Ant says OK OK git to work buster. Very funnish start but wut about yor topic title?
- 5 How th'Irth Wint Rong. Tell me wut you has to tell, says the Big Ant. Hoo wins th'essay contist gits a hole ham for the wintir. Go for it, Hapless Joey. Yu needs it, yor wasting away, I kin see yor ribs thru yor parka. I kin see yor thinkings thru yor hairliss skalp. Yu gits ideers fast enuff. Put yor mind on the paje.

OK OK.

- 10 Big Ant sits and luks at papers from othr kids. Looks at papers. Im not riting this over. She sits herself up by th'stove nere the best hot part. She says she kint unnerstand a singul wird of wut she is lukiing at. I got to git myself unnerstud.

Topic title: How th'Irth Wint Rong by Hapless Joey @ homeskool.guv

- (Big Ant says, that last bit. Homeskool dot guv. Thats fake. Britetime writing. From back in the days of internet and puters. Take it out she says. I dont. I think it looks cool. Maybe
- 15 puters will be invented again. Sum day. Besides, she not suppoz to tell me stuff. Thay want to see how I kin think for my self.)

I am Hapless Joey. I am not a liddle kid. I am not a groanup. I am tall as th'pegs for cotes in th'halfway. I waz liddle wonce now I'm not so mutch.

- 20 I liv in a shack. Hoo dont, yu say but lots dont. My dore gots a lock an my winders gots glass. I im here with my grandid Ole Joey an sometimes Big Ant come over. She suppoz to be fare but this hous is not so windy and cold as some so I gits mor uv hir time. That's wy I cin rite so gud. Good. Big Ant is good teecher but she eets a lot. She's Big Ant. She gots to close hir coat with a rope. Lurning me to rite makes hir hungerful I gess. Me to.

- 25 Note to Commity: This is Big Ant and I have no intrist in a ham or in getting out of the stupid bone-chilling cold. Hapless Joey has some wits about him so pay attention to what he says. Im not allowed to correct his work but I cant stand by and let him slag me off without pitching a comment about it. His house aint all that warm neither.

- Also I aint that big, just got a big heart as any Sinner will tell you and a big heart needs a big
- 30 rib cage to hold it and stout legs to stand it up and walk it about. I only use a rope around my coat becawse a dog cawt my belt onct when I was walking home with a chicken curry courtesy of Sector Admin. who admire my work with kids by the way.

I waz born a short time befor the Cold Time startd. My grandid tells me all the time abowt the wirlld then. Its hard to beleve wut he says. I cint member I wuz a baby. But them pickchrs
35 in buks books bux whatever, thay dont lie. I seen cars withowt rust an I seen green yards like blankets put down. The grass green awl so smooth. I seen a sky with no clowds, awl sweet an blu lik the cleanest sheet yu ever seen. In pickchrs I seen it, torn from books an handg up in th Pickchr Plase calld the Multiplecks.

Back then th'Irth was fuller. More warm. More cleen. Peepul culd fly arownd in metal rumez
40 with wings an go here an there. Over to Yurup an Japan an Afrika. An other playcis that uzd to exist. Thay culd go and cum back like eezy peezy wuts the problem? Thay culd go on big ships ovir the water. Thay culd liv in Parisfrants or in Lundininglind or in Romittly. Thay dint think nuthin uv it, thay just livd like you an me. Well bettr then you an me becaws that wuz befor th'Irthsore happin.

45 The Big Ant says OK OK I got to rite abowt th'Irthsore. Thass my hole point. Th'Irthsore that chaynjd the wirlld. That made Cold Time.

Back wen my parints wer yung an just chirchd, thay was a mom an a dad too, just like in sum of them pickshrs, th'Irth it wuz cleen and all ficksd up. Cars slid up and forth the streets. Sinners culd tawk on littl metel cards with numbrs on them. Thru th'air I meen,
50 like if you had a frend in Berlinjerminey or Athnsgrese you just like sed sum numbrs and they sed sum numbrs back an it was like, Hi, how ar you, how is it over there in Parisfrantz or Kieroejipt. Evrybuddy did it all the time like it wuz nuthing spexial. Speshul. Spejal. Nuthing unyoujewel.

Note to Commity: This is Big Ant again an you see a brake here in the story because Hapless
55 Joey smashed his pencil in distress. He spells better than most but that dont mean nothing to him. He wants to get it write. Thats what marks him owt for spexhul notice. I told him stop with bragging all those cities, theys all gone and you do yourself no favors reminding the Commity so he stopps. But he likes geogriphy and maps as you can see so planely. He started writing agin a few days later. Its with a color pencil but its still his work. He is good
60 dont you agree.

I dont member enny uv this. Th'Irth before Coldtime. Its mor like a dreem sumbuddy have. But Grandid and Big Ant member fine an others to. Two. Too.

Grandid uze to go to liberry, an it uze to be free. Also opin. He culd reed most anything he wantd to. He unnerstands sum uv wat happind. He told me an now I im telling yu. Ywo.
65 Yoo

Damm damm damm. I hate spelling its not lawful.

OK OK. I im bettr now.

Here is wat happind. Back then th'Irth wuz pirfect an men had jobs an cash and womin had soft yello hair an didnt need so many cotes. Thay culdn feel the cold I gess. It wuz a time
70 of heros an moving stars on th'Irth. Grandid livd then so did Big Ant. So did my parints. Th'Irth wen I git born wuz still paradize only nobuddy new it wuz.

With awl the big masheens an stuff life wuz eezy an warm an lots uv food. An pepul culd go arownd the wirlld to plases like Nirobiafrika. An China an Oztrailya.

The peepul all think thay is smartr than God. Thay make a mashine in the mowntens be-
75 twene France an Switzrland. It is big it is ugly it is powrfull. It makes the motes in God's eye go fastr an fastr in a big tunnl a hunderd miles long. A sircul tunnl, rownd an rownd. Peepul

call'd Siontists thay study the spede uv the parts. The dust uv the wirl'd. The smithireens uv the planet. The motes uv God's eye. Wow thay say wow, wow! wow! We make the crums an bits uv the wirl'd run fastr.

80 Wy du thay do this yu ask. Its a gud kwestchun. I do not no the anser.

Then wun day God gits mad at peepul playing with th'Irth. The peepul spin the motes so fast rownd and rownd thay meet themselv's coming the othr way. God lets it happn. God lets the durt in the tunnl hit itself. Hard. Thass wat peepul now think. I wuz only a baby but Grandid says he woke up during th'Irthsore an the hole morning was braking up lik threds on the edj uv a carpit.

It wuz 6 in the morning an he culd see me in my crib in the morning lite. My hands wir trying to clap but thay culdnt. Evrything in the wirl'd wuz pulling to wun side. Like static lectrisity back wen thay had lectrisity. My baby hand an the crib an the winder wir awl pulling. Brok up into eech othr. Lik meltd mud an snow an crud draggd awl wun way by a stick with fings. 90 Grandids legs an the sheets wir awl pulling like taffy an he culdnt moove to git me. It stayd lik that for an owr or so then it pool'd back to normil.

But it wuz not the same normil. Maybe an owr or maybe time got pulld too.

Thay sed on the streets that the big tunnl cullap'd. Maebe it made a nu kind uv dust that dint like th'Irth. Or maebe it made a tiny mowth in th'Irth that wuz hungry an wantd to eet th'Irth. Or it wuz maebe spots uv Nothing an it dissolv'd th'Irth as far as it culd. But 95 Nothing cant exist by itself or nobuddy wuld notiss it, says the Chirch Man. Nothing ate the haff of th'Irth that wuz on that side. Wen it finish'd haff it tride to go on but th' othr haff of Nothing is Sumthing. It was ar haff of th'Irth so we stayd Sumthing.

The othr haff the dark haff is Nothing. No wun unnerstands wut is in it Nothing I gess. 100 Haff a planit uv Sumthing, haff a planit uv Nothing. Pirfect balans.

Just darck. Darck Nothing.

Why is that I wunder.

OK OK. The end.

Note to Commity: Now you see what I am trying to show you. Hapless Joey is a good boy and he knows a lot. This is the best pece of riting I seen in four or five years. I think you shuld 105 also know that his parents were in Moscow or someplace when the SuperCollider collapsed. Like half the wirl'd they never been hird from again.

It is my belief he deserve the ham. I culd come get it just give the say-so.

Dear Big Ant, The Committee has reviewed the writing of Hapless Joey and agrees with you that he is special material. Will you bring him to Central next week, any day you like, and we 110 will train him up to be a missile into the Dark Edge. We have only sent ten or twelve people in ten years, and one day one of them will come back and tell us what they found there. Hapless Joey may be the lucky one. His name is the opposite of lucky, and something is the opposite of nothing. Don't tell Hapless Joey what he has won. He may need to grow up more to appreciate the honor. We don't want him to run away. You may keep the ham for yourself 115 after you give him up.

The Doll's House

Katherine Mansfield

1922

When dear old Mrs. Hay went back to town after staying with the Burnells she sent the children a doll's house. It was so big that the carter and Pat carried it into the courtyard, and there it stayed, propped up on two wooden boxes beside the feed-room door. No harm could come to it; it was summer. And perhaps the smell of paint would have gone off by the time
5 it had to be taken in. For, really, the smell of paint coming from that doll's house ("Sweet of old Mrs. Hay, of course; most sweet and generous!") – but the smell of paint was quite enough to make anyone seriously ill, in Aunt Beryl's opinion. Even before the sacking was taken off. And when it was ...

There stood the doll's house, a dark, oily, spinach green, picked out with bright yellow. Its
10 two solid little chimneys, glued on to the roof, were painted red and white, and the door, gleaming with yellow varnish, was like a little slab of toffee. Four windows, real windows, were divided into panes by a broad streak of green. There was actually a tiny porch, too, painted yellow, with big lumps of congealed paint hanging along the edge.

But perfect, perfect little house! Who could possibly mind the smell. It was part of the joy,
15 part of the newness.

"Open it quickly, someone!"

The hook at the side was stuck fast. Pat pried it open with his penknife, and the whole house front swung back, and – there you were, gazing at one and the same moment into the drawing-room and dining-room, the kitchen and two bedrooms. That is the way for a
20 house to open! Why don't all houses open like that? How much more exciting than peering through the slit of a door into a mean little hall with a hatstand and two umbrellas! That is – isn't it? – what you long to know about a house when you put your hand on the knocker. Perhaps it is the way God opens houses at the dead of night when He is taking a quiet turn with an angel ...

"O-oh!" The Burnell children sounded as though they were in despair. It was too marvellous; it was too much for them. They had never seen anything like it in their lives. All the rooms were papered. There were pictures on the walls, painted on the paper, with gold frames complete. Red carpet covered all the floors except the kitchen; red plush chairs in the drawing-room, green in the dining-room; tables, beds with real bedclothes, a cradle, a stove, a dresser
30 with tiny plates and one big jug. But what Kezia liked more than anything, what she liked frightfully, was the lamp. It stood in the middle of the dining-room table, an exquisite little amber lamp with a white globe. It was even filled all ready for lighting though, of course, you couldn't light it. But there was something inside that looked like oil and moved when you shook it.

35 The father and mother dolls, who sprawled very stiff as though they had fainted in the drawing-room, and their two little children asleep upstairs, were really too big for the doll's house.

They didn't look as though they belonged. But the lamp was perfect. It seemed to smile at Kezia, to say, "I live here." The lamp was real.

40 The Burnell children could hardly walk to school fast enough the next morning. They burned to tell everybody, to describe, to – well – to boast about their doll's house before the school-bell rang.

"I'm to tell," said Isabel, "because I'm the eldest. And you two can join in after. But I'm to tell first."

45 There was nothing to answer. Isabel was bossy, but she was always right, and Lottie and Kezia knew too well the powers that went with being eldest. They brushed through the thick buttercups at the road edge and said nothing.

"And I'm to choose who's to come and see it first. Mother said I might."

50 For it had been arranged that while the doll's house stood in the courtyard they might ask the girls at school, two at a time, to come and look. Not to stay to tea, of course, or to come traipsing through the house. But just to stand quietly in the courtyard while Isabel pointed out the beauties, and Lottie and Kezia looked pleased ...

55 But hurry as they might, by the time they had reached the tarred palings of the boys' playground the bell had begun to jangle. They only just had time to whip off their hats and fall into line before the roll was called. Never mind. Isabel tried to make up for it by looking very important and mysterious and by whispering behind her hand to the girls near her, "Got something to tell you at playtime."

60 Playtime came and Isabel was surrounded. The girls of her class nearly fought to put their arms round her, to walk away with her, to beam flatteringly, to be her special friend. She held quite a court under the huge pine trees at the side of the playground. Nudging, giggling together, the little girls pressed up close. And the only two who stayed outside the ring were the two who were always outside, the little Kelveys. They knew better than to come anywhere near the Burnells.

65 For the fact was, the school the Burnell children went to was not at all the kind of place their parents would have chosen if there had been any choice. But there was none. It was the only school for miles. And the consequence was all the children of the neighbourhood, the judge's little girls, the doctor's daughters, the store-keeper's children, the milkman's, were forced to mix together. Not to speak of there being an equal number of rude, rough little boys as well. But the line had to be drawn somewhere. It was drawn at the Kelveys. Many of the children, including the Burnells, were not allowed even to speak to them. They walked past 70 the Kelveys with their heads in the air, and as they set the fashion in all matters of behaviour, the Kelveys were shunned by everybody. Even the teacher had a special voice for them, and a special smile for the other children when Lil Kelvey came up to her desk with a bunch of dreadfully common-looking flowers.

75 They were the daughters of a spry, hardworking little washerwoman, who went about from house to house by the day. This was awful enough. But where was Mr. Kelvey? Nobody knew for certain. But everybody said he was in prison. So they were the daughters of a washerwoman and a gaolbird. Very nice company for other people's children! And they looked it. Why Mrs. Kelvey made them so conspicuous was hard to understand. The truth was they were dressed in 'bits' given to her by the people for whom she worked. Lil, for instance, 80 who was a stout, plain child, with big freckles, came to school in a dress made from a green art-serge table-cloth of the Burnells, with red plush sleeves from the Logans' curtains. Her

hat, perched on top of her high forehead, was a grown-up woman's hat, once the property of Miss Lecky, the postmistress. It was turned up at the back and trimmed with a large scarlet quill. What a little guy she looked! It was impossible not to laugh. And her little sister, our
85 Else, wore a long white dress, rather like a nightgown, and a pair of little boy's boots. But whatever our Else wore she would have looked strange. She was a tiny wishbone of a child, with cropped hair and enormous solemn eyes – a little white owl. Nobody had ever seen her smile; she scarcely ever spoke. She went through life holding on to Lil, with a piece of Lil's skirt screwed up in her hand. Where Lil went, our Else followed. In the playground, on
90 the road going to and from school, there was Lil marching in front and our Else holding on behind. Only when she wanted anything, or when she was out of breath, our Else gave Lil a tug, a twitch, and Lil stopped and turned round. The Kelveys never failed to understand each other.

Now they hovered at the edge; you couldn't stop them listening. When the little girls turned
95 round and sneered, Lil, as usual, gave her silly, shamefaced smile, but our Else only looked.

And Isabel's voice, so very proud, went on telling. The carpet made a great sensation, but so did the beds with real bedclothes, and the stove with an oven door.

When she finished Kezia broke in. "You've forgotten the lamp, Isabel."

"Oh, yes," said Isabel, "and there's a teeny little lamp, all made of yellow glass, with a white
100 globe that stands on the dining-room table. You couldn't tell it from a real one."

"The lamp's best of all," cried Kezia. She thought Isabel wasn't making half enough of the little lamp. But nobody paid any attention. Isabel was choosing the two who were to come back with them that afternoon and see it. She chose Emmie Cole and Lena Logan. But when the others knew they were all to have a chance, they couldn't be nice enough to Isabel. One
105 by one they put their arms round Isabel's waist and walked her off. They had something to whisper to her, a secret. "Isabel's my friend."

Only the little Kelveys moved away forgotten; there was nothing more for them to hear.

Days passed, and as more children saw the doll's house, the fame of it spread. It became the one subject, the rage. The one question was, "Have you seen Burnells' doll's house? Oh,
110 ain't it lovely!" "Haven't you seen it? Oh, I say!"

Even the dinner hour was given up to talking about it. The little girls sat under the pines eating their thick mutton sandwiches and big slabs of johnny cake spread with butter. While always, as near as they could get, sat the Kelveys, our Else holding on to Lil, listening too, while they chewed their jam sandwiches out of a newspaper soaked with large red blobs ...

115 "Mother," said Kezia, "can't I ask the Kelveys just once?"

"Certainly not, Kezia."

"But why not?"

"Run away, Kezia; you know quite well why not."

At last everybody had seen it except them. On that day the subject rather flagged. It was the
120 dinner hour. The children stood together under the pine trees, and suddenly, as they looked at the Kelveys eating out of their paper, always by themselves, always listening, they wanted to be horrid to them. Emmie Cole started the whisper.

"Lil Kelvey's going to be a servant when she grows up."

“O-oh, how awful!” said Isabel Burnell, and she made eyes at Emmie.

125 Emmie swallowed in a very meaning way and nodded to Isabel as she’d seen her mother do on those occasions.

“It’s true – it’s true – it’s true,” she said.

Then Lena Logan’s little eyes snapped. “Shall I ask her?” she whispered.

“Bet you don’t,” said Jessie May.

130 “Pooh, I’m not frightened,” said Lena. Suddenly she gave a little squeal and danced in front of the other girls. “Watch! Watch me! Watch me now!” said Lena. And sliding, gliding, dragging one foot, giggling behind her hand, Lena went over to the Kelveys.

Lil looked up from her dinner. She wrapped the rest quickly away. Our Else stopped chewing. What was coming now? “Is it true you’re going to be a servant when you grow up, Lil Kelvey?” shrilled Lena.

135 Dead silence. But instead of answering, Lil only gave her silly, shamefaced smile. She didn’t seem to mind the question at all. What a sell for Lena! The girls began to titter.

Lena couldn’t stand that. She put her hands on her hips; she shot forward. “Yah, yer father’s in prison!” she hissed, spitefully.

140 This was such a marvellous thing to have said that the little girls rushed away in a body, deeply, deeply excited, wild with joy. Someone found a long rope, and they began skipping. And never did they skip so high, run in and out so fast, or do such daring things as on that morning.

In the afternoon Pat called for the Burnell children with the buggy and they drove home.

145 There were visitors. Isabel and Lottie, who liked visitors, went upstairs to change their pinafores. But Kezia thieved out at the back. Nobody was about; she began to swing on the big white gates of the courtyard. Presently, looking along the road, she saw two little dots. They grew bigger, they were coming towards her. Now she could see that one was in front and one close behind. Now she could see that they were the Kelveys. Kezia stopped swinging. She slipped

150 off the gate as if she was going to run away. Then she hesitated. The Kelveys came nearer, and beside them walked their shadows, very long, stretching right across the road with their heads in the buttercups. Kezia clambered back on the gate; she had made up her mind; she swung out.

“Hullo,” she said to the passing Kelveys.

155 They were so astounded that they stopped. Lil gave her silly smile. Our Else stared.

“You can come and see our doll’s house if you want to,” said Kezia, and she dragged one toe on the ground. But at that Lil turned red and shook her head quickly.

“Why not?” asked Kezia.

Lil gasped, then she said, “Your ma told our ma you wasn’t to speak to us.”

160 “Oh, well,” said Kezia. She didn’t know what to reply. “It doesn’t matter. You can come and see our doll’s house all the same. Come on. Nobody’s looking.”

But Lil shook her head still harder.

“Don’t you want to?” asked Kezia.

165 Suddenly there was a twitch, a tug at Lil's skirt. She turned round. Our Else was looking at her with big, imploring eyes; she was frowning; she wanted to go. For a moment Lil looked at our Else very doubtfully. But then our Else twitched her skirt again. She started forward. Kezia led the way. Like two little stray cats they followed across the courtyard to where the doll's house stood.

"There it is," said Kezia.

170 There was a pause. Lil breathed loudly, almost snorted; our Else was still as stone. "I'll open it for you," said Kezia kindly. She undid the hook and they looked inside. "There's the drawing-room and the dining-room, and that's the –"

"Kezia!"

Oh, what a start they gave!

175 "Kezia!"

It was Aunt Beryl's voice. They turned round. At the back door stood Aunt Beryl, staring as if she couldn't believe what she saw.

180 "How dare you ask the little Kelveys into the courtyard?" said her cold, furious voice. "You know as well as I do, you're not allowed to talk to them. Run away, children, run away at once. And don't come back again," said Aunt Beryl. And she stepped into the yard and shooed them out as if they were chickens.

"Off you go immediately!" she called, cold and proud.

185 They did not need telling twice. Burning with shame, shrinking together, Lil huddling along like her mother, our Else dazed, somehow they crossed the big courtyard and squeezed through the white gate.

"Wicked, disobedient little girl!" said Aunt Beryl bitterly to Kezia, and she slammed the doll's house to.

190 The afternoon had been awful. A letter had come from Willie Brent, a terrifying, threatening letter, saying if she did not meet him that evening in Pulman's Bush, he'd come to the front door and ask the reason why! But now that she had frightened those little rats of Kelveys and given Kezia a good scolding, her heart felt lighter. That ghastly pressure was gone. She went back to the house humming.

195 When the Kelveys were well out of sight of Burnells', they sat down to rest on a big red drain-pipe by the side of the road. Lil's cheeks were still burning; she took off the hat with the quill and held it on her knee. Dreamily they looked over the hay paddocks, past the creek, to the group of wattles where Logan's cows stood waiting to be milked. What were their thoughts? Presently our Else nudged up close to her sister. But now she had forgotten the cross lady. She put out a finger and stroked her sister's quill; she smiled her rare smile.

"I seen the little lamp," she said, softly. Then both were silent once more.

New Zealand Prime Minister Addresses United Nations General Assembly

Jacinda Ardern

2019

Ko ngā tangata katoa, e manaakitia ana te whenua, o te Ao Whānui (To all those who care for the lands of the wide world) Ko ngā kaitiaki, e riterite ana, ngā whenua, huri rauna, i te Ao (To the guardians of sustainability around the world) Me tū tatou ki te werohia I ngā wero (Stand and challenge the challenges) I te ingoa o te tika o ngā mea katoa (In the name of what is right with all things.) Tēnā koutou katoa (Greetings to you all)

Mr. President,

Mr. Secretary-General,

Friends,

I greet you in te reo Māori, language of the tangata whenua, or first people of Aotearoa New Zealand. I do so not just because it is the same way I would begin an address if I were at home, but because there are challenges we face as a world that I know no better way to express. Māori concepts like kaitiakitanga. The idea that each of us here today are guardians. Guardians of the land, of our environment and of our people. There is a simplicity to the notion of sovereign guardianship.

For decades we have assembled here under the assumption that we narrowly cooperate only on the issues that overtly impact on one another; issues like international trade rules, the law of the sea, or humanitarian access to war zones. The space in between has essentially been left to us. We, the political leaders of the world, have been the authors of our own domestic politics and policies. Decisions have been our own, and we have ultimately lived with the consequences.

But the world has changed.

Over time we have become increasingly interdependent. We see more and more often domestic decisions that have global ramifications.

Physical events have taught us that in obvious ways: oil spills that show no respect for maritime boundaries; nuclear accidents and testing, the impacts of which are never confined to the exact location in which they occur.

But our interdependence, our connection, runs so much deeper than that, and experiences in recent years should lead us all to question whether any of us ever truly operate in isolation anymore.

This is a question that we, the remote but connected nation of New Zealand, have been grappling with this year.

There are things that we are well known for in New Zealand. Green rolling hills, perfect you

might say for hobbits to hide and for plenty of sheep to roam. We're known for manaakitanga, or the pride we take in caring for our guests, so much so that it even extends to our most entrenched sporting rivals.

And now we are known for something else.

The 15th of March 2019.

The day an alleged terrorist undertook the most horrific attack on a place of worship, taking the lives of 51 innocent people, devastating our Muslim community and challenging our sense of who we are as a country.

Now there is no changing a nation's history, but we can choose how it defines us. And in Aotearoa New Zealand, the people who lined up outside of mosques with flowers, the young people who gathered spontaneously in parks and open spaces in a show of solidarity, the thousands who stopped in silence to acknowledge the call to prayer seven days later, and the Muslim community who showed only love – these are the people who collectively decided that New Zealand would not be defined by an act of brutality and violence, but instead by compassion and empathy.

Make no mistake though, we do not claim to be a perfect nation. While we are a home of more than 200 ethnicities, that does not mean we are free from racism and discrimination. We have wounds from our own history that, 250 years on from the first encounters between Māori and Europeans, we continue to address.

But since the terrorist attack in New Zealand, we have had to ask ourselves many hard and many difficult questions.

One example sticks in my mind. It was only days after the shooting and I visited a mosque in our capital city. After spending some time with community leaders, I exited and walked across the car park where members of the Muslim community were gathered. And out of the corner of my eye I saw a young boy gesture to me. He was shy, almost retreating towards a barrier, but he also had something he clearly wanted to say. I quickly crouched down next to him.

He didn't say his name or even hello, he simply whispered, "Will I be safe now?"

What does it take for a child to feel safe? As adults, we are quick to make the practical changes that will enable us to say that such a horrific act could never happen again. And we did that. Within 10 days of the attack we made a decision to change our gun laws and banned military style semi-automatic weapons and assault rifles in New Zealand. We have started on a second tranche of reforms to register weapons and to change our licensing regime.

These changes will help to make us safer. But when you're a child, fear is not discrete, and it cannot be removed through legislative acts or decrees from Parliament.

Feeling safe means the absence of fear. Living free from racism, bullying and discrimination. Feeling loved, included and able to be exactly who you are. And to feel truly safe, those conditions need to be universal. No matter who you are, no matter where you come from, no matter where you live.

The young Muslim boy in Kilbirnie, New Zealand, wanted to know if I could grant him all of those things.

My fear is, that as a leader of a proudly independent nation, this is one thing that I cannot achieve alone. Not anymore.

In our borderless and technologically connected world, commentary on race, acts of discrimination based on religion, gender, sexuality or ethnicity – they are not neatly confined behind boundaries. They are felt globally.

80 The fact I received so many letters from Muslim children from around the world in the weeks after March 15 speaks to the power of connection. These children had no sense of distance. They may have never heard of New Zealand before March 15. They just saw an act of hatred against their community, and it felt close to them.

85 Whether it is acts of violence, language intended to incite fear of religious groups or assumptions about ethnicities to breed distrust and racism – these actions and utterances are as globalised as the movement of goods and services.

Children hear them.

Women hear them.

People of faith hear them.

Our rainbow communities hear them.

90 And so now, it's our turn to stop and to listen. To accept that our words and actions have immeasurable consequences. And to speak not only like the whole world is listening, but with the responsibility of someone who knows a small child somewhere might be listening too.

95 The spaces in which we communicate, they are part of the challenge too, tough. In an increasingly online world we need to create spaces for the exchange of ideas, the sharing of technology and free speech, but also acknowledging the potential for this technology to be used to cause harm.

100 March 15 was a staggering example of such harm, and a deliberate effort to broadcast terror on a massive, viral scale over the internet. The alleged terrorist didn't just take the lives of 51 people, he did it live on Facebook.

In the first 24 hours after the attack, Facebook took down 1.5 million copies of the livestream video. YouTube saw a copy of the video uploaded, at times, as fast as once every second during the same period.

105 The alleged terrorist used social media as a weapon. The attack demonstrated how the internet, a global commons with extraordinary power to do good, can be perverted and used as a tool for terrorists.

110 And so what happened in Christchurch, as well as being a profound tragedy, is also a complex and ongoing problem for the world. And it's a problem we felt a sense of responsibility to do something about, so we sought to collaborate with the technology companies so integral to the solution.

Two months after the attacks, leaders gathered in Paris for the Christchurch Call, bringing together companies, countries and civil society, and committing to a range of actions to reduce the harm this content can cause. In doing so we have kept our focus on the deeper aim we all want: technology that unleashes human potential, not the worst in us.

115 Yesterday, I met with Call supporters to check in on our collective progress. We announced that a key tech industry institution will be reshaped to give effect to those commitments – and we launched a crisis response protocol to make sure that we can respond to such events in the future.

Neither New Zealand nor any other country could make these changes on their own. The
120 tech companies couldn't either. We are succeeding because we are working together, and for
that unprecedented and powerful act of unity New Zealand says thank you.

The centrality of technology in our lives is not the only example though of our increasing in-
terconnection and our reliance on one another if we are to respond to the challenges we face.
There is perhaps no better example of our absolute interdependence than climate change.

125 When the United Nations Secretary-General visited the Pacific region this year, he saw first-
hand how countries that have produced the fewest greenhouse gas emissions are now facing
the most catastrophic effects. In his words: "To save the Pacific is to save the whole planet."

In fact, seven out of the 15 most climate-affected nations in the world sit within the Pacific
region. Places like Tuvalu, with a population of just over 11,000 people, barely contributes to
130 global emissions but is paying the price for our collective inaction. Atolls so low lying that in
weather events the water on either side of it can flow together and join at the narrowest points.
Engulfed by the sea. Or Tokelau, a beautiful set of three atolls that can only be accessed by
boat, where the children speak knowledgeably about climate change, knowing that unlike all
of the challenges their self-reliant forbears have ever faced, this is the one that is completely
135 and utterly in other people's hands.

Now they have never met you, nor you them. But I can tell you that their expectations on all
of us are high.

Meeting those expectations will require us to use every policy lever available – and, just like
the Christchurch Call to Action, we need to work with partners inside and outside govern-
140 ment to make change.

[...]

We are being asked to make decisions that are local, but with consequences that are global.

And yet, this is what climate change requires us to do. That is what historically our commit-
ment to the United Nations Charter and the Universal Declaration of Human Rights asks
145 us to do. It's what standing up against acts of violence and discrimination asks us to do. Our
globalised, borderless world asks us to be guardians not just for our people, but for all people.

There may have been a time when being unified under common challenges was an easier
concept than it is today. But undeniably, we are living in a time where our greater reliance
on one another has collided with a period of greater tribalism.

150 It would be wrong to assume that this is a new phenomenon. Research, in fact, has shown
that humans are in fact so inclined to form natural tribes that if you put a completely uncon-
nected diverse group of people into a room and flip a coin for each, those two groups will
automatically form a suspicion of one another based on nothing more than heads vs tails.

Scientist and writer Robert Sapolsky recently reminded us that humans organise. Whether
155 it's class, race, country or coin flipping – there has always been a tendency to form us vs other.

But he also asks the question: what if we change what 'us' means? If instead of fierce nation-
alism or self-interest, we seek to form our tribes based on concepts that can and should be
universal.

What if we no longer see ourselves based on what we look like, what religion we practise, or
160 where we live. But by what we value. Humanity. Kindness. An innate sense of connection
to each other. And a belief that we are guardians, not just of our home and our planet, but of

each other.

We are borderless, but we are connected.

We are inherently different, but we have more that we share.

¹⁶⁵ We may feel afraid, but as leaders we have the keys to create a sense of security, and a sense of hope.

We just need to choose.

Tātou tātou. No reira, tena koutou, tena kontou, tena koutou hatoa.